Class 6 Social Science – Chapter 6

The Beginnings of Indian Civilisation

All textbook questions, activities, and important topic-wise questions with answers in Simple English

These answers are based on your uploaded CBSE textbook chapter. The language is kept simple for Class 6 students and useful for school examinations.

Part 1: Answers to all textbook questions

Q1. Why does the civilisation studied in this chapter have several names? Discuss their significance.

Answer: This civilisation has several names because it spread across a large region and was discovered at different places.

- Indus Civilisation: It was first discovered at places near the Indus River.
- Harappan Civilisation: Harappa was one of the first cities of this civilisation to be excavated in 1920–21.
- Indus-Sarasvati Civilisation: Many settlements were found near both the Indus and the Sarasvati river systems.
- Sindhu-Sarasvati Civilisation: Sindhu is another name for the Indus River.

All these names refer to the same ancient civilisation.

Q2. Write a brief report (150 to 200 words) summarising some of the achievements of the Indus-Sarasvati Civilisation.

Answer:

The Indus-Sarasvati Civilisation was one of the oldest civilisations in the world. It flourished mainly between about 2600 BCE and 1900 BCE. Its people, called Harappans, built well-planned cities such as Harappa, Mohenjo-daro, Dholavira and Lothal.

The cities had wide streets, brick houses and organised drainage systems. Many houses had separate bathing areas. Mohenjo-daro had a famous structure called the Great Bath. The people built wells, reservoirs and drains to manage water. Dholavira had large reservoirs for collecting and storing water.

The Harappans practised agriculture and grew wheat, barley, millets and sometimes rice. They also grew cotton and made clothes. They domesticated animals and caught fish. Skilled craftspeople made ornaments, beads, pottery, tools and seals.

The Harappans traded with other regions by land, rivers and sea. Lothal had a large basin believed to have been used as a dockyard. The civilisation showed advanced town planning, water management, farming, craft production and trade.

Q3. Imagine you have to travel from the city of Harappa to Kalibangan. What are your different options? Can you make a rough estimation of the amount of time each option might take?

Answer: In Harappan times, I could travel from Harappa to Kalibangan in the following ways:

1. On foot: It would take several days because walking is slow.
2. By bullock cart: It might take a few days, depending on the condition of the roads and the speed of the cart.
3. By boat, where waterways were suitable: It might be possible to travel along connected waterways, but the journey would depend on the route and river conditions.

These are rough estimates, not exact historical travel times. The textbook does not provide exact distances, routes or travel speeds for this journey.

Q4. Imagine a Harappan man or woman being transported to an average kitchen in today's India. What are the four or five biggest surprises awaiting them?

Answer: A Harappan person would be surprised to see:

1. Electric appliances such as refrigerators, mixers and microwave ovens.
2. Modern cooking methods, including gas stoves and induction cooktops.
3. Modern utensils made of stainless steel, aluminium and other materials.
4. Packaged and processed foods available in shops.
5. Running water and modern taps, which make it easy to obtain water.

They might also be surprised by the use of electricity and the wide variety of food available today.

Q5. Looking at all the pictures in this chapter, make a list of ornaments, gestures and objects that still feel familiar in our 21st century.

Answer:

The following objects and practices shown in the chapter are still familiar today:

- Bangles and beads

- Combs and mirrors
- Pots and cooking utensils
- Toys and whistles
- Games and game boards
- Seals and decorative designs
- The namaste gesture
- Jewellery and other ornaments

These examples show that some objects, designs and gestures from Harappan life are still familiar to us.

Q6. What mindset does the system of reservoirs at Dholavira reflect?

Answer: The reservoirs at Dholavira show that the Harappans were organised, practical and careful about water conservation. They understood the importance of storing rainwater and managing water supplies. The reservoirs and connecting drains also suggest planning, teamwork and the need for an organised system to maintain public facilities.

Q7. In Mohenjo-daro, about 700 wells built with bricks have been counted. They seem to have been regularly maintained and used for several centuries. Discuss the implications.

Answer: The large number of wells suggests that the people of Mohenjo-daro gave great importance to water supply. The wells provided water for drinking, cooking and bathing. Their regular maintenance shows that the people understood the need to keep water sources usable. It also suggests skilled construction, organised community effort and some system for maintaining public facilities.

Q8. It is often said that the Harappans had a high civic sense. Discuss the significance of this statement. Do you agree with it? Compare with citizens in a large city of India today.

Answer: Civic sense means behaving responsibly in public places and caring for community facilities. I agree that the Harappans showed a high civic sense because they built planned streets, drainage systems, wells and reservoirs.

People in modern Indian cities also need civic sense. They should keep streets clean, use dustbins, avoid blocking drains, save water and protect public property. Modern cities have advanced technology, but good planning and responsible behaviour are still essential.

Part 2: Important questions and answers from every topic

Topic 1: What Is a Civilisation?

Q1. What is a civilisation?

Answer: A civilisation is an advanced stage of human society in which people live in organised communities and develop cities, administration, crafts, trade and cultural practices.

Q2. What are the main characteristics of a civilisation?

Answer: The main characteristics are:

1. Government and administration
2. Planned towns and cities
3. Different crafts and skilled occupations
4. Internal and external trade
5. A system of writing
6. Cultural ideas, art and social customs
7. Productive agriculture to feed people in villages and cities

Q3. What is urbanism?

Answer: Urbanism means the growth and planning of towns and cities, including the management of streets, water and drainage.

Q4. What is metallurgy?

Answer: Metallurgy is the process of extracting metals from nature, purifying them and combining them to make useful materials.

Q5. Why is productive agriculture important for a civilisation?

Answer: Productive agriculture provides enough food for people living in villages and cities. It also supports craftspeople, traders and other workers who may not grow their own food.

Q6. Why does a civilisation need government and administration?

Answer: Government and administration help manage people, organise work, maintain public facilities and coordinate the activities of a large society.

Q7. Why is writing useful in a civilisation?

Answer: Writing helps people keep records, communicate information and preserve ideas.

Q8. When did civilisation begin in Mesopotamia and ancient Egypt?

Answer: According to the chapter, civilisation began in Mesopotamia about 6,000 years ago. Ancient Egyptian civilisation developed a few centuries later.

Q9. When did the Indus-Sarasvati Civilisation flourish?

Answer: It flourished mainly between about 2600 BCE and 1900 BCE.

Q10. Which occupations might exist in a civilisation?

Answer: Farmers, traders, potters, builders, metalworkers, craftspeople, administrators, writers and transport workers might exist in a civilisation.

Topic 2: From Village to City

Q1. Where did the Indus-Sarasvati Civilisation develop?

Answer: It developed mainly in the north-western part of the Indian Subcontinent, across a large region connected with the Indus and Sarasvati river systems.

Q2. Why were the river plains suitable for agriculture?

Answer: Rivers provided water, and their surrounding plains had fertile soil. These conditions were favourable for growing crops.

Q3. How did villages grow into towns and cities?

Answer: Villages produced agricultural goods. As trade and other exchanges increased, some villages grew into towns and then into cities.

Q4. What is the First Urbanisation of India?

Answer: The growth of villages into large, organised towns and cities during the Indus-Sarasvati Civilisation is called the First Urbanisation of India.

Q5. Why is the term “Indus Valley Civilisation” considered insufficient?

Answer: The civilisation extended far beyond the Indus Valley. Many settlements were also found in the Sarasvati region and other areas. Therefore, “Indus-Sarasvati Civilisation” describes its wider spread more clearly.

Q6. Why are the inhabitants of this civilisation called Harappans?

Answer: They are called Harappans because Harappa was one of the first cities of this civilisation to be excavated, in 1920–21.

Q7. What is a tributary?

Answer: A tributary is a river or stream that flows into a larger river or lake.

Q8. What is a fortification?

Answer: A fortification is a strong wall built around a settlement or city, generally for protection.

Q9. What is meant by an elite group?

Answer: An elite group consists of people who hold a higher position in society, such as rulers, officials and administrators.

Q10. Name some important Harappan cities and their modern regions as given in the textbook.

Harappan city	Modern state/region in the textbook
Dholavira	Gujarat
Harappa	Punjab
Kalibangan	Sindh
Mohenjo-daro	Haryana
Rakhigarhi	Rajasthan

Important note: The table above reproduces the entries as printed in the textbook. Some city-region pairings appear inconsistent with modern geography, so follow your teacher's guidance if asked to reproduce this particular textbook table.

Topic 3: The Sarasvati River

Q1. What is the Sarasvati River called today in the regions mentioned in the chapter?

Answer: The chapter identifies the river with the Ghaggar in India and the Hakra in Pakistan. Therefore, it refers to the Ghaggar-Hakra river system.

Q2. Why was the Sarasvati River important to the civilisation?

Answer: Many Harappan settlements developed along the Sarasvati river system. The river provided water and supported agriculture and settlement.

Q3. What does the Rig Veda say about Sarasvati?

Answer: The Rig Veda mentions Sarasvati as both a goddess and a river flowing from the mountains towards the sea.

Q4. What happened to the Sarasvati River?

Answer: Later texts describe the river as drying up and eventually disappearing. The chapter also states that the river dried up in its central basin, contributing to the abandonment of some settlements.

Q5. Why is the river now seasonal in parts of its course?

Answer: According to the chapter, the river now flows only during the rainy season in the regions described.

Topic 4: Town Planning

Q1. What were the main features of Harappan cities?

Answer: Harappan cities had:

- Wide and planned streets
- Brick houses
- Organised drainage systems
- Wells and other water facilities
- Large public structures
- In many cities, fortifications
- Separate upper and lower town areas

Q2. How were the streets of Harappan cities planned?

Answer: The streets were laid out according to careful plans. Many were wide and followed the cardinal directions, such as north, south, east and west.

Q3. What were the upper town and lower town?

Answer: In many Harappan cities, the upper town was probably used by local elites, while the lower town was where common people lived.

Q4. What materials were commonly used to build Harappan buildings?

Answer: Most buildings were made of bricks. At Dholavira, the foundations of many buildings were made of stone.

Q5. What were large buildings possibly used for?

Answer: Some large buildings may have been used for collective purposes, such as storing goods in warehouses. The exact purpose of some structures is still debated.

Q6. What was the Great Bath?

Answer: The Great Bath was a large, carefully constructed tank at Mohenjo-daro. It had waterproofing materials, steps and a drain to empty the tank.

Q7. What might the Great Bath have been used for?

Answer: Archaeologists have suggested that it may have been used for religious rituals or by the royal family. Its exact purpose is not known. The textbook notes that a public bathing purpose is less likely because many houses had their own bathrooms.

Q8. What is the importance of Harappan town planning?

Answer: It shows that the Harappans had good planning skills, knowledge of construction and an organised way of managing urban life.

Topic 5: Water Management

Q1. Why did the Harappans give importance to water management?

Answer: Water was needed for drinking, cooking, bathing and agriculture. The Harappans developed systems to obtain, store and remove water.

Q2. How did Harappan houses manage wastewater?

Answer: Many houses had separate bathing areas connected to drains. These drains often ran below the streets and carried wastewater away.

Q3. How did people obtain water in Mohenjo-daro?

Answer: People obtained water from hundreds of brick-built wells.

Q4. How did Dholavira manage water?

Answer: Dholavira had large reservoirs built with stone or cut into rock. Many were connected by underground drains to collect, store and distribute water efficiently.

Q5. What is a reservoir?

Answer: A reservoir is a natural or artificial place where water is stored.

Q6. What does the water system at Dholavira tell us about its people?

Answer: It shows that the Harappans planned carefully, understood the importance of conserving water and could organise large construction and maintenance projects.

Q7. Why were drains important in Harappan cities?

Answer: Drains carried wastewater away from houses and streets. They helped keep residential areas cleaner and made urban life more organised.

Q8. What can we learn from the wells of Mohenjo-daro?

Answer: The large number of wells, and their long period of use, suggests that water supply was carefully planned and that people maintained important community facilities.

Topic 6: What Did the Harappans Eat?

Q1. Which crops did the Harappans grow?

Answer: They grew wheat, barley, some millets and sometimes rice. They also grew pulses and vegetables.

Q2. Which fibre crop did the Harappans grow?

Answer: They grew cotton and used it to make cloth. The chapter describes them as the first people in Eurasia to grow cotton.

Q3. What farming tools did the Harappans use?

Answer: They used farming tools, including the plough. The chapter shows a small clay model of a plough found at Banawali in Haryana.

Q4. Why were many settlements built near rivers?

Answer: Rivers provided water for daily use and agriculture. The land around rivers was also often fertile.

Q5. How did the Harappans obtain animal food?

Answer: They domesticated animals for meat and caught fish in rivers and the sea. Archaeologists have found animal and fish bones during excavations.

Q6. What do the remains found in Harappan cooking pots tell us?

Answer: Scientific examination of clay pots has revealed remains of dairy products and ingredients such as turmeric, ginger and banana. This suggests that their diet was varied.

Q7. Why did cities depend on villages?

Answer: Villages produced food, which had to reach cities regularly. Without enough agricultural produce from rural areas, cities could not survive.

Q8. What might a Harappan meal have included?

Answer: Based on the foods mentioned in the chapter, a meal might have included wheat or barley, vegetables, pulses and dairy products. Other foods could have included millets, rice, fish or meat, depending on availability.

Topic 7: A Brisk Trade

Q1. Did the Harappans trade only within their own region?

Answer: No. They traded within their own civilisation and with other regions and civilisations, both inside and outside the Indian Subcontinent.

Q2. What goods did the Harappans export?

Answer: They exported ornaments, timber and some everyday objects. They may also have exported gold, cotton and certain food items.

Q3. Which ornaments were especially popular?

Answer: Beads made of carnelian, a reddish semi-precious stone found mainly in Gujarat, were especially popular.

Q4. What skills did Harappan craftspeople develop?

Answer: They developed special techniques to drill carnelian beads and make ornaments. They also worked with hard conch shells to make beautiful bangles.

Q5. Which metal did the Harappans probably import?

Answer: They probably imported copper because it was not very common in their home region.

Q6. What is bronze?

Answer: Bronze is a metal alloy made by combining copper with tin. It is harder than copper alone.

Q7. What did the Harappans make from bronze?

Answer: They used bronze to make tools, pots and pans, and some figurines.

Q8. Which routes did the Harappans use for trade?

Answer: They used land routes and rivers. They also used the sea to reach more distant destinations.

Q9. What was Lothal known for?

Answer: Lothal, a Harappan settlement in Gujarat, had a very large basin that the textbook identifies as a probable dockyard for receiving and sending boats carrying goods.

Q10. What were Harappan seals used for?

Answer: The chapter suggests that seals helped traders identify their goods and possibly one another. Many seals were made of steatite, a soft stone that could be hardened by heating.

Q11. What do the seals tell us about Harappan writing?

Answer: The seals contain animal figures and signs belonging to a writing system. However, the writing and the symbolic meanings of the figures have not yet been fully understood.

Q12. Why is Harappan trade important?

Answer: Trade connected different settlements, helped exchange goods and encouraged the growth of crafts and cities.

Topic 8: The Lives of the Ancients

Q1. What objects used by the Harappans have archaeologists discovered?

Answer: Archaeologists have found pottery, mirrors, stone weights, bronze tools, combs, toys, whistles, games boards, seals, beads and figurines.

Q2. What do these objects tell us about Harappan life?

Answer: They show that the Harappans had developed crafts and used a variety of tools and household objects. They also enjoyed games, wore ornaments and made objects with cultural or symbolic meanings.

Q3. What is the “Priest King” figurine?

Answer: It is a famous statuette found at a Harappan site. It is often called the “Priest King”, but the identity and actual role of the person represented are not known.

Q4. What is the Dancing Girl?

Answer: The Dancing Girl is a small bronze figurine found at Mohenjo-daro. It is about 10.8 cm high and shows a young figure wearing many bangles.

Q5. What does the Dancing Girl figurine tell us?

Answer: It shows the Harappans' skill in metalwork and figurine-making. The bangles also remind us of ornaments that are still worn in some parts of India.

Q6. What is the Pashupati Seal?

Answer: It is a Harappan seal depicting a three-faced figure seated on a raised platform and surrounded by powerful animals. Its exact meaning remains uncertain.

Q7. What do toys and game boards tell us?

Answer: They suggest that games and play were part of Harappan life for both children and adults.

Q8. What can we learn from the picture on the Lothal pot?

Answer: The picture appears to show a thirsty crow finding a clever way to drink water from a pot. It suggests that stories and ideas could be represented through images, although its exact interpretation is not certain.

Topic 9: The End or a New Beginning?

Q1. When did the Indus-Sarasvati Civilisation begin to decline?

Answer: The civilisation began to decline around 1900 BCE.

Q2. What happened to its cities?

Answer: The cities were gradually abandoned. Some people moved to smaller rural settlements and adopted a more rural lifestyle.

Q3. Was warfare the main cause of the decline?

Answer: The chapter says that there is no clear evidence of warfare or invasion destroying the cities. The Harappans do not appear to have maintained an army or weapons of war on a large scale.

Q4. What were the two important factors linked to the decline?

Answer:

1. Climate change: Reduced rainfall made the climate drier, which made agriculture more difficult and reduced food supplies.
2. The drying of the Sarasvati River: Its central basin dried up, and settlements such as Kalibangan and Banawali were abandoned.

The chapter notes that other factors may also have played a role.

Q5. Why did people return to rural settlements?

Answer: Rural settlements offered closer access to food and water. Cities depended on villages for agricultural produce, so difficulties in food and water supply affected urban life.

Q6. Did Harappan culture disappear completely?

Answer: No. Although the cities declined, much of Harappan culture and technology survived and was passed on to later phases of Indian civilisation.

Q7. What lesson does the decline of this civilisation teach us?

Answer: It teaches us that human societies depend greatly on climate, water and the environment. Changes in these can affect agriculture, food supplies and settlements.

Part 3: Important activity and discussion questions

These questions are based on the “Think About It” and “Let’s Explore” sections of the chapter.

Q1. Which characteristic of a civilisation is the most fundamental?

Answer: Productive agriculture is one of the most fundamental characteristics because it provides food for the whole society. Without enough food, cities, crafts, trade and administration cannot develop easily.

Q2. What does the construction of large reservoirs tell us about Harappan administration?

Answer: It suggests that workers had to be organised, instructions had to be given, and the reservoirs needed regular maintenance. This points to planning and some form of local authority or administration.

Q3. Why was the Great Bath carefully constructed?

Answer: The Great Bath had carefully laid bricks and waterproofing material. This shows that its builders had good construction skills and wanted to prevent water from leaking.

Q4. How can we learn about Harappan life when their writing is not understood?

Answer: We can study houses, streets, drains, wells, pottery, tools, seals, ornaments, animal bones and other objects discovered by archaeologists.

Q5. Why should we be careful while interpreting ancient objects?

Answer: One object may have several possible uses or meanings. Without written records or other evidence, archaeologists may not be able to determine its exact purpose.

Q6. What does the system of wells and drains suggest about Harappan cleanliness?

Answer: It suggests that water supply, bathing and the removal of wastewater were important parts of urban life. These facilities also indicate organised planning.

Q7. Why were seals useful in trade?

Answer: Seals may have helped traders identify their goods and conduct exchanges. They often showed animal figures and writing signs.

Q8. What does the similarity between ancient and modern ornaments suggest?

Answer: It suggests that some designs and ways of wearing ornaments have continued over a long period. However, similarity alone does not prove that every custom has remained unchanged.

Part 4: Important definitions for examinations

Term	Simple meaning
Civilisation	An advanced and organised human society
Urbanism	The planning and growth of towns and cities
Metallurgy	The process of extracting and working with metals
Tributary	A river that flows into a larger river or lake
Fortification	A strong wall built for protection
Elite	A group of people with a high position in society
Reservoir	A place where water is stored
Archaeologist	A person who studies the past through material remains
Excavation	The careful digging of a site to discover remains of the past
Carnelian	A reddish semi-precious stone used to make beads
Steatite	A soft stone used to make many Harappan seals
Bronze	An alloy made mainly of copper and tin
Dockyard	A place where boats or ships can be received and handled
Civic sense	Responsible behaviour towards public places and community facilities
Rural	Related to villages and the countryside
Climate change	A change in the usual patterns of climate over time

Part 5: Quick revision – important facts

Period of the civilisation

About 2600 BCE–1900 BCE.

Important cities

Harappa, Mohenjo-daro, Dholavira, Lothal, Kalibangan and Rakhigarhi.

Water management

Wells, drains, reservoirs and the Great Bath.

Agriculture

Wheat, barley, millets, sometimes rice, pulses, vegetables and cotton.

Trade

Land routes, rivers and sea routes; Lothal had a large basin believed to be a dockyard.

Decline

Likely linked to reduced rainfall, environmental changes and the drying of the Sarasvati River.

Part 6: Very important short-answer questions

1. What were the people of the Indus-Sarasvati Civilisation called?

They were called Harappans.

2. Which city had the famous Great Bath?

Mohenjo-daro.

3. Which Harappan settlement is associated with a large dockyard?

Lothal.

4. Which city is especially known for its large reservoirs?

Dholavira.

5. Which material was used to make many Harappan seals?

Steatite.

6. Which semi-precious stone was used to make popular beads?

Carnelian.

7. What did the Harappans use to make cloth?

They grew cotton and used it to make cloth.

8. What were the main causes associated with the decline of the civilisation in this chapter?

Reduced rainfall and the drying of the Sarasvati River are the two factors highlighted in the textbook.

9. What is the First Urbanisation of India?

It is the development of villages into towns and cities during the Indus-Sarasvati Civilisation.

10. What is the main contribution of the Harappans highlighted in this chapter?

Their planned cities, efficient water management, productive agriculture, skilled crafts and active trade.

Part 7: Practice test

Try answering these questions without looking at the answers above.

MCQ Test

0 of 8 answered

1. Which city is famous for the Great Bath?

Harappa
Mohenjo-daro
Lothal
Rakhigarhi

2. Which Harappan settlement had large reservoirs?

Dholavira
Harappa
Kalibangan
Mohenjo-daro

3. Which crop was used to make cloth?

Rice
Barley
Cotton
Pulses

4. What is a tributary?

A city wall
A river flowing into a larger river or lake
A storage building
A type of seal

5. What was one likely reason for the decline of the civilisation?

The invention of writing
Reduced rainfall
The discovery of bronze
The building of wells

6. What was steatite used for?

Making seals
Growing crops
Building boats only
Making cotton cloth

7. What does Harappan drainage tell us?

They did not plan cities
They cared about water management and cleanliness
They lived only in villages
They did not use bricks

8. Between which dates did the civilisation flourish mainly?

5000–4000 BCE
2600–1900 BCE
1000–500 BCE
500–100 BCE
Check answers

Exam tip: Learn the definitions, the names and features of the major cities, the Great Bath, water management, agriculture, trade, seals, and the reasons for the civilisation’s decline. These topics cover the main ideas of Chapter 6.